UCC 301.COM 422 L2

Classification of research

There are many ways to classify research studies, and authors use classification systems of varying degrees of complexity. Essentially, classification systems are valuable to the extent that they are useful for enhancing the effectiveness and efficiency by which research is conducted. Research can be classified from three different perspectives:

- Application of the findings of the research study
- Objectives of the study
- Mode of enquiry used in conducting the study

The classification of a study on the basis of these three perspectives is not mutually exclusive; that is, a research study classified from the viewpoint of application can be classified from the perspectives of objectives and enquiry mode.

Classification Application

Basic Research

Basic research advances fundamental knowledge about the social world. It attempts to address the fundamental questions surrounding a discipline. Occasionally, researchers make significant findings that have great impact on the direction or development of existing schools of thought. Basic research is often criticized as wasteful and useless despite the fact that it is the source of newest scientific ideas and ways of thinking about the world.

Applied Research

In contrast to basic research, applied researchers argue that funding should only be spent on scientific projects that aim to solve a specific policy, social or environmental issue. Applied researchers are numerous in type and number.

Types of Applied Research

a. Action Research

Is applied research that treats knowledge as a form of power and attempts to abolish the line between research and social action. In other words, the goals of the researcher are often motivated based upon an unequal distribution of social, political, and financial power. For example, research

focuses on power with a goal of empowerment; research seeks to raise consciousness or increase awareness; and research is tied directly to political action.

b. Social Impact Assessment

Its purpose is to measure the likely consequences of a planned change. Areas assessed in impact studies include: Community Service; Social Conditions; Economic Impact; Demographic Consequences; Environment; Health Outcomes; Psychological Well Being

c. Evaluation Research

Is a widely used type of applied research that addresses the question, "Did it work?" In other words, evaluation researchers actively engage in assessing the success or failure of a social program, organization, etc. There exist two types of evaluation research. Both of which are usually used in conjunction with each other.

Types of Evaluation Research

- Formative Evaluation

Consist of built-in monitoring or continuous feedback on a program used for program management.

- Summative Evaluation

Looks only at the final outcome.

d. The Time Dimension in Research

Cross-Sectional Research: In this type of study, researchers observe at one point in time. Cross sectional studies are simpler and less costly than longitudinal studies.

Longitudinal Research: Longitudinal researchers examine features of people or other units at more than one point in time. Longitudinal studies can be very costly and complex.

- Types of Longitudinal Studies

Time Series: A longitudinal study in which the same type of information is collected on a group of people or other units across multiple time periods.

Panel Study: The researcher observes exactly the same people, group, or organization across several time periods. This type of research is very costly and many times may be impossible due to its potential price tag.

Cohort Analysis: A longitudinal study that studies a category of people who share a similar life experience within a specified time period.

Case Study: A special type of longitudinal study in which a researcher examines in depth many features of a few cases over a long duration of time. Often times the data collected includes very detailed and personal information about a person, organization, etc.

Types of research: Objectives perspective

Descriptive research: A research study classified as a descriptive study attempts to describe systematically a situation, problem, phenomenon, service or programme, or provide information about the living conditions of a community, or describe attitudes towards an issue.

Correlational research: The main emphasis in a correlational study is to discover or establish the existence of a relationship/ association/ interdependence between two or more variables or more aspects of a situation.

Explanatory research: this kind of research attempts to clarify why and how there is a relationship between two aspects of a situation or phenomenon.

Exploratory research: it is a study which is undertaken to explore an area where little is known or to investigate the possibilities of undertaking a particular research study. It is flexible and can answer what, who and why questions. When a study is carried out to determine its feasibility, it is also called a feasibility study or a pilot study. It is usually carried out when a researcher wants to explore an area about which s/he has little or no knowledge. A small scale study is undertaken to decide if it is worth carrying out a detailed study.

Classification by mode of enquiry used in conducting the study/orientation/ approach

They are: qualitative, quantitative and mixed methods

Qualitative research

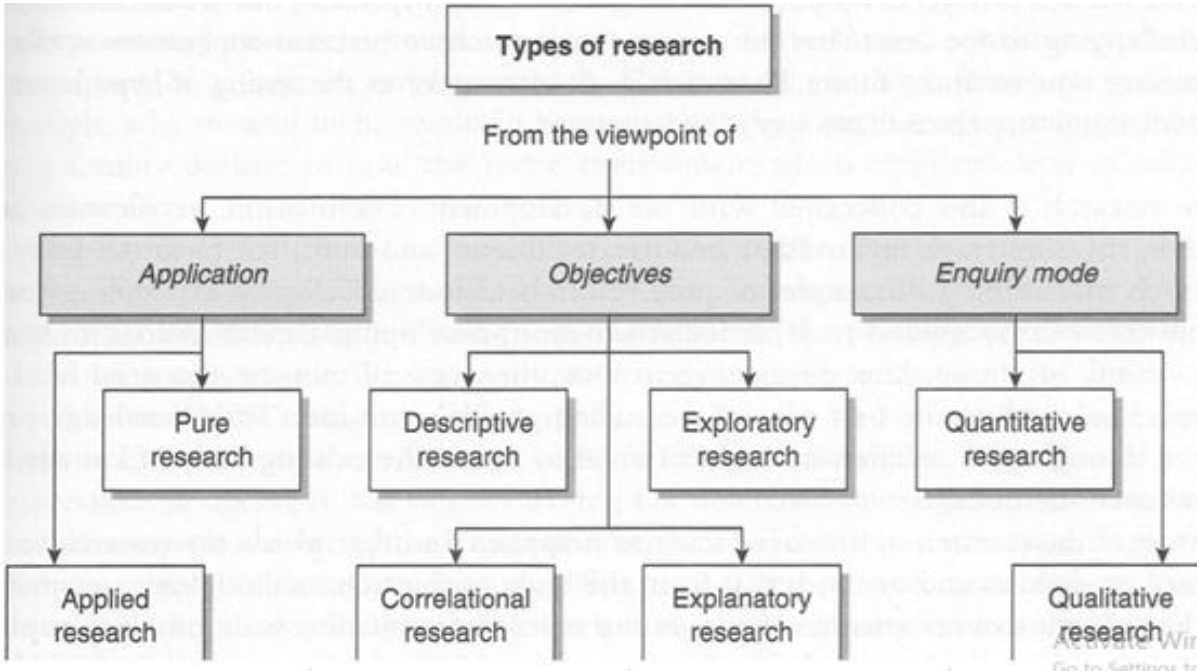
Qualitative research focuses on the quality of things – what is their nature? What are they like? How can they be described? It often involves the views or internal worlds of participants, and may include data generated through the use of interviews, focus groups, etc. Qualitative research often gathers data from relatively small samples of people, and can provide a 'micro' view of whatever issues you are examining. The relatively small amount of data does not, however, make the researcher's job easier. Because qualitative data often take the form of words, narratives and descriptions, which are not easy to analyze, the researcher must do a lot of intelligent interpretation of these data to identify relevant themes and to make these understandable and credible for the reader.

Advantages of qualitative research	Limitations of qualitative research
i. Rich, in-depth detail is possible (e.g. participants can elaborate on what they mean) ii. Perceptions of participants themselves can be considered (the human factor) iii. Appropriate for situations in which detailed understanding is required iv. Events can be seen in their proper context / more holistically	i. Not always generalizable due to small sample sizes and the subjective nature of the research ii. Conclusions need to be carefully hedged Accusations of unreliability are common (different results may be achieved on a different day/with different people)

Quantitative research

Quantitative data focuses on the quantity of things – how many are there? What are the statistical patterns? It generally takes the form of numbers, and their analysis involves counting or quantifying these to draw conclusions. Large r sets of data will be involved than is the case with qualitative research, and statistically rigorous techniques are used to analyse these. Quantitative data often provide a 'macro' view, in that they involve large samples.

Advantages of quantitative research	Limitations of quantitative research
i. Larger sample sizes often make the conclusions from quantitative research generalizable ii. Statistical methods mean that the analysis is often considered reliable iii. Appropriate for situations where systematic, standardised comparisons are needed	i. Does not always shed light on the full complexity of human experience or perceptions ii. Can reveal what / to what extent, but cannot always explore why or how iii. May give a false impression of homogeneity in a sample



Mixed Research Methods

There are two major types of mixed research are distinguished: mixed method versus mixed model research.

• Mixed method research– is research in which the researcher uses the qualitative research paradigm for one phase of a research study and the quantitative research paradigm for another phase of the study. For example, a researcher might conduct an experiment (quantitative) and after the experiment conduct an interview study with the participants (qualitative) to see how they

viewed the experiment and to see if they agreed with the results. Mixed method research is like conducting two mini-studies within one overall research study.

• Mixed model research– is research in which the researcher mixes both qualitative and quantitative research approaches within a stage of the study or across two of the stages of the research process. For example, a researcher might conduct a survey and use a questionnaire that is composed of multiple closed-ended or quantitative type items as well as several open-ended or qualitative type items. For another example, a researcher might collect qualitative data but then try to quantify the data.